Gita, stressing ‘I am imperishable Time’. As a verse in the *Maitreya Upanishad* puts it:

From time all beings emerge
From time they advance and grow
In time, too, they come to rest.
Time is embodied and also bodiless.

The harm religion does when it is passionately self-righteous—wars, crusades, communal violence, jihad—is arguably greater than the benefits religion produces when it does well (teaching morality, answering prayers, providing balm to troubled souls). In its long history, Hinduism has never launched an apocalyptic war of religion or tried to impose one correct answer on all of life. Hindus like to speak of theirs as a religion of peace, but then so do other faiths. Still, the Hindu scriptures are replete with hymns to peace, and are infused with the idea that human beings must seek peace within themselves and peace with all other human beings. Many Vedic mantras set out to achieve these ends; of these the Shanti Mantra is the most famous, and prays for peace in heaven, on earth and in the human heart. The words ‘Om Shantih! Shantih! Shantihi!’ are uttered three times at the end of every sacred action or after the recitation of a sacred text—three times because the Hindu seeks peace in all three realms. Humans cannot enjoy personal peace in the absence of peace on earth, but equally there cannot be peace in the world if there is no peace in the inner hearts of the human beings in the world. A verse of the *Yajur Veda* (xxxvi, 17) chants:

To the heavens be peace, to the sky and the earth,
To the waters be peace, to plants and all trees,
To the Gods be peace, to Brahman be peace,
To all men be peace, again and again—peace also to me![7]

The speaker of the Sixteenth Lok Sabha, the Lower House of the Indian parliament, the first in that office from the BJP, introduced the practice of uttering ‘Om Shantih! Shantih! Shantihi!’ after the otherwise ritualistic reading of obituary notices during each session. Though this implied the introduction of religious language into a secular Parliament, her words were echoed by many MPs, and not only those of her party. While as a liberal I was initially dismayed by her doing this, I soon came